across new processing centres in Mumbai, Chennai, and the NCR region of Delhi, handling work not just for ABN AMRO but also several other major international banks.

While we were building ACES, the bank started a microfinance programme, which I mentored. Through our microfinance lending, we financed over 6,50,000 women across the country, empowering them to lift themselves and their families out of poverty. When the microfinance crisis in Andhra Pradesh started to choke this lifeline of credit, I secured approval to set up a foundation that would provide outright grants, training and market access to the poorest women.

Over the years, I took the opportunity to travel to their villages and live with many of our women beneficiaries in their homes. It was a great learning to see first-hand how effectively they used small amounts of seed capital, often as little as ?5,000, to build successful businesses and transform their lives. Their entrepreneurial talent, ability to work long hours and generosity of spirit were heart-warming and inspiring. Many of the women we financed stood for local elections in their villages and districts – providing efficient and competent governance and changing the lives of those in their community.

In 2005, I was appointed as the Chief Operations Officer for Asia, overseeing countries from Dubai in the West to Australia and Japan in the East. As we had successfully transferred banking operations to India, I now proposed that we consider outsourcing the bank's IT operations, this time to the major Indian IT companies. As a senior member of the global team overseeing the process, I was delighted when Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) and Infosys were selected on merit. For both TCS and Infosys, this was a landmark deal and the single largest, multi-year, multi-million contract that either had ever won to date, leading to the creation of many jobs in India and valuable export earnings.

During this time, I was selected for the Advanced Management Programme at the Harvard Business School where I was fortunate to